Meanwhile, Anna University, Madras, conferred the honorary degree of Doctor of Science on me. It had been nearly twenty years since I had acquired my degree in aeronautical engineering. I was happy that Anna University had recognized my efforts in the field of rocketry, but what pleased me most was the recognition of the value of our work in academic circles. To my delight, the honorary doctorate degree was awarded at a convocation presided over by Prof. Raja Ramanna.

I joined DRDL on 1 June, 1982. Very soon, I realized that this laboratory was stil haunted by the winding up of the Devil missile project. Many excel ent professionals had not yet recovered from the disappointment. People outside the scientific world may find it difficult to comprehend how a scientist feels when the umbilical cord to his work is suddenly snapped, for reasons total y alien to his understanding and interests. The general mood and work tempo at DRDL reminded me of Samuel Taylor Coleridge's poem The Rime of the Ancient Mariner:

Day after day, day after day,

We stuck, nor breath, nor motion;

As idle as a painted ship